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(AI-Generated Session Notes)

AI Transformation From the CEO Seat: From Executive Mandate to Everyday Work

Date & time: Oct. 14, 9:15-9:45 AM
Track: Featured Main Stage



Craig Karmazin

Founder and CEO, Good Karma Sports

- LinkedIn



Ty Bauschek

Senior Director of Innovation and Sales Development, Good Karma Sports

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Mike Kaput MODERATOR

Chief Content Officer, SmarterX

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Session Description

What happens after a CEO tells 500+ employees that AI will be one of the biggest transformations in the company's history?

For Good Karma Sports, that was only the beginning.

Founder and CEO Craig Karmazin and Senior Director of Innovation and Sales Development Ty Bauschek will share what happened next from two sides of the

transformation. Karmazin will unpack why he chose to go all in on AI and what he expected from the organization. Bauschek will share what it took to turn that vision into action across the company.

With new innovation roles, redesigned workflows, and AI becoming part of everyday work, Karmazin and Bauschek will offer a candid look at what it really takes to move from executive vision to companywide change.

Key Quote

> *"Every time someone leaves our company, my first question is: Can we use this as an opportunity to grow the careers of our existing team?"* - **Craig Karmazin**
>
> *"Innovation shouldn't be telling our teammates, who are subject matter experts, how the work should get done. We're just helping them get to that point."* - **Ty Bauschek**

Session Summary

Moderated by Mike Kaput, Chief Content Officer at SmarterX, this conversation brought together Good Karma Sports founder and CEO Craig Karmazin and Ty Bauschek, senior director of innovation and sales development, to share how the 500-plus-employee sports media and marketing company went all in on AI. In a little over a year, more than 65% of employees now use AI daily.

Karmazin explained that the company had pivoted before, from radio to sports and later into digital, but this time he believed that if it didn't transform within three years, it wouldn't exist. After rereading The Coming Wave by Mustafa Suleyman, he told the entire company that anyone who didn't embrace AI likely wouldn't have a job a year from now. He now spends more than half his device time in AI, which has freed him for more human work, like 19 face-to-face meetings during a recent visit to the company's L.A. office.

Bauschek, who had never logged into AI before that call, said reactions ranged from excitement to resistance. The difference was permission to play and to fail: leadership distributed licenses and crowdsourced the best uses instead of dictating them. Good Karma Sports is now building its own software, modernizing workflows to get out of Excel, and reimagining work, such as cutting a two-to-three-hour campaign-building process to about 10 minutes. Its innovation specialists came from within, after excelling at applying AI to their own work.

Both were candid about the challenges. Karmazin admitted he painted with too broad a brush, since some teammates have talents that transcend AI, and that managers who aren't leaned in can become bottlenecks. Bauschek said the hardest part is keeping pace with AI, which requires biweekly training and regular back-to-basics sessions. Karmazin benchmarks workflows on time and quality, scales only innovations that make work faster and better, and views every departure as a chance to grow existing teammates' careers.

On talent, Karmazin said the company has created three new careers and that AI-native entry-level hires can elevate the rest of the organization. Bauschek urged leaders to have patience urgently, and Karmazin closed with a lesson he credited to Bauschek: AI didn't raise the floor for everyone, but it raised the ceilings of the hungriest teammates.

Key Takeaways

- **Set a clear mandate from the top.** Karmazin's direct, companywide message made AI a business imperative and gave teammates clear permission to experiment and fail.
- **Crowdsource use cases instead of dictating them.** Rather than prescribing how to use AI, Good Karma Sports rolled out licenses and let subject matter experts discover the best applications in their own work.
- **Build innovation teams from within.** The company's innovation specialists were teammates who had already excelled at applying AI to their own jobs, and pilot-group teammates become the most credible advocates for new workflows.
- **Aim for faster and better, not just faster.** Karmazin benchmarks each workflow on time and quality and only scales an innovation when it improves the output rather than making it 90% as good.
- **Watch for manager bottlenecks.** Leaders who aren't leaned into AI can stop the flow of information, so organizations need multiple touchpoints to discover teammates doing great work.
- **Invest in your hungriest teammates.** AI raised the ceilings of the most driven teammates rather than the floor for everyone, so leaders should do everything they can to grow them.